PADHAKU
First Flight · Class 10 English



CHAPTER 3

Two Stories about Flying

NCERT Exercise Solutions

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✨ Try each question yourself first, then check the answer. 💡 answers are samples: write your own.

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His First Flight · Thinking about the Text

1 **Why was the young seagull afraid to fly? Do you think all young birds are afraid to make their first flight, or are some birds more timid than others? Do you think a human baby also finds it a challenge to take its first steps?**

✔ ANSWER

The young seagull was afraid because the sea below looked like a great expanse, "miles down". He felt certain that "his wings would never support him". So he lacked self-confidence and failed to "muster up courage" to take the plunge.

Not all young birds are equally afraid. His brothers and sister, whose wings were shorter than his, flew without fear. So some birds are more timid than others.

Yes, a human baby also finds its first steps a challenge. It is afraid of falling, but with the encouragement of its parents it gathers courage and learns to walk.

2 **“The sight of the food maddened him.” What does this suggest? What compelled the young seagull to finally fly?**

✔ ANSWER

It suggests that the seagull was extremely hungry. He had not eaten since the previous nightfall, so seeing his mother tear at a piece of fish made him desperate for food.

Hunger compelled him to fly. When his mother stopped just out of reach with the fish in her beak, he dived at it, "maddened by hunger". He fell into space, his wings spread out, and he began to fly.

3 **“They were beckoning to him, calling shrilly.” Why did the seagull’s father and mother threaten him and cajole him to fly?**

✔ ANSWER

His parents knew that he could fly but was held back only by fear. Every bird must learn to fly to find food and live on its own.

So they scolded him, threatened to let him starve on his ledge, and taunted him for his cowardice. Later the mother tempted him with food, and the family beckoned him to land on the sea. They did all this to help him overcome his fear and become independent.

4 **Have you ever had a similar experience, where your parents encouraged you to do something that you were too scared to try? Discuss this in pairs or groups.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Points for discussion (sample):

- When I was in Class 5 my school asked me to speak on the stage on Independence Day. I was too scared of the crowd.
- My parents made me practise the speech at home every evening and told me that mistakes do not matter.
- On the day, my father sat in the front row and smiled at me. I spoke without stopping and everyone clapped.
- Like the seagull, I learnt that fear goes away once we take the first step, and parents' encouragement gives us that push.

5 **In the case of a bird flying, it seems a natural act, and a foregone conclusion that it should succeed. In the examples you have given in answer to the previous question, was your success guaranteed, or was it important for you to try, regardless of a possibility of failure?**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

My success was not guaranteed. I could have forgotten my speech or stammered in front of everyone.

But it was important to try, regardless of the possibility of failure. Without trying, I would never have known that I could do it. Even a failure would have taught me something and made the next attempt easier. Trying is the first step to success.

⭐ His First Flight · Speaking

1 **We have just read about the first flight of a young seagull. Your teacher will now divide the class into groups. Each group will work on one of the following topics. Prepare a presentation with your group members and then present it to the entire class.**

- **Progression of Models of Airplanes**
- **Progression of Models of Motorcars**
- **Birds and Their Wing Span**
- **Migratory Birds — Tracing Their Flights**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

Sample presentation outline: **Progression of Models of Airplanes**

- **Introduction:** Humans always dreamt of flying like birds.
- **1903:** The Wright brothers' Flyer made the first powered, controlled flight (about 12 seconds).

- **World War I–II (1914–1945):** Biplanes, then faster metal monoplanes such as the Dakota (DC-3), a famous passenger and cargo plane.
- **1950s:** Jet airliners (e.g. Boeing 707) made long-distance travel quick.
- **1969–1976:** The Boeing 747 "jumbo jet" and the supersonic Concorde.
- **Today:** Light, fuel-saving planes (Airbus A350, Boeing 787), drones and research on electric aircraft.
- **Conclusion:** From 12 seconds to non-stop flights across the world in about 120 years.

Other groups can follow the same plan: introduction, stages/examples with dates or facts, pictures/charts, conclusion. (Migratory birds: e.g. Siberian cranes and bar-headed geese that fly to India in winter.)

⭐ His First Flight · Writing

1 **Write a short composition on your initial attempts at learning a skill. You could describe the challenges of learning to ride a bicycle or learning to swim. Make it as humorous as possible.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

My Battle with the Bicycle

When I was nine, my uncle gifted me a shiny red bicycle. I thought riding it would be as easy as sitting on a chair. How wrong I was!

On the first day my elder brother held the seat and told me to pedal. I pedalled like a racing champion, while the bicycle wobbled like a jelly. The moment he let go, the handle turned on its own and I went straight into Sharma aunty's flower bed. Her roses were not amused, and neither was she.

The next day I decided to look at the road and not at my feet. This time I crashed into a sleepy cow, who only looked at me as if to say, "Not again." My knees collected more bandages than medals.

On the fifth day, my brother quietly let go without telling me. I rode all the way to the end of the lane before I realised I was alone. Then, of course, I panicked and fell — but I had ridden!

Like the young seagull, I learnt that the fear is bigger than the task. Today I ride to school every day, and I always wave politely at Sharma aunty's roses.

🤔 The Black Aeroplane · Thinking about the Text

1 **"I'll take the risk." What is the risk? Why does the narrator take it?**

✔ ANSWER

The risk was flying his old Dakota straight into the huge storm clouds that looked like black mountains. He could not fly over them and did not have enough fuel to fly around them.

He took the risk because he wanted to get home to England. He was dreaming of his holiday, his family and "a good big English breakfast", so he did not want to go back to Paris.

2 **Describe the narrator's experience as he flew the aeroplane into the storm.**

✔ ANSWER

- Inside the clouds everything was suddenly black; he could see nothing outside.
- The old aeroplane "jumped and twisted in the air".
- The compass turned "round and round"; it and the other instruments went dead. The radio was dead too, so he could not contact Paris Control.
- He was lost in the storm, and his last fuel tank was running low. He felt frightened.

- Then a strange black aeroplane without lights appeared. Its pilot waved, "Follow me", and led him through the storm for over half an hour. When fuel was left for only five or ten minutes, the plane went down, and the narrator came out of the clouds to see a runway and landed safely.

3 **Why does the narrator say, “I landed and was not sorry to walk away from the old Dakota...”?**

✔ ANSWER

He had just had a terrifying experience in the old Dakota. Its compass, radio and other instruments had failed in the storm, and it had almost run out of fuel. He had escaped death narrowly, so he felt relieved and was not sorry to leave the plane and be on safe ground.

4 **What made the woman in the control centre look at the narrator strangely?**

✔ ANSWER

The narrator asked her about the pilot of the other aeroplane, as he wanted to thank him. She looked at him strangely because no other aeroplanes were flying that night. Only his plane had appeared on the radar, so his question about another plane in the storm seemed strange to her.

5 **Who do you think helped the narrator to reach safely? Discuss this among yourselves and give reasons for your answer.**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

The story leaves it a mystery. Some possible views:

- **A guardian angel / divine help:** the plane had no lights, did not appear on radar and vanished as soon as he was safe — so it was no ordinary plane.
- **His own mind (imagination):** in great fear, his mind may have created the helper; his instinct and courage guided him to the airport.
- **The ghost of a pilot** who had perhaps died in a similar storm.

In my opinion it was some supernatural help, because the woman saw only one plane on the radar, yet the narrator clearly saw the pilot's face and followed him to a runway he could not have found alone.

🤔 The Black Aeroplane · Thinking about Language

I **Guess the meanings of the word ‘black’ in the sentences given below. Check the meanings in the dictionary and find out whether you have guessed right.**

✔ ANSWER

Sentence	Meaning of ‘black’
1. Your hands and face are absolutely black.	very dirty
2. The taxi-driver gave Ratan a black look ...	an angry / hostile look (full of dislike)
3. ... one of the blackest crimes against humanity.	most evil / wicked / shameful
4. ... Harold Pinter’s black comedy.	comedy that makes fun of serious or unpleasant things like death (dark humour)
5. ... sell these in black.	illegally, at a higher price (in the black market)
6. ... beaten the criminal black and blue.	beaten very badly, so the body is covered with bruises

II **Match the phrases given under Column A with their meanings given under Column B: 1. Fly a flag 2. Fly into rage 3. Fly along 4. Fly high 5. Fly the coop. (B: Move**

quickly/suddenly; Be successful; Display a flag on a long pole; Escape from a place; Become suddenly very angry)

✔ ANSWER

A	B
1. Fly a flag	Display a flag on a long pole
2. Fly into rage	Become suddenly very angry
3. Fly along	Move quickly/suddenly
4. Fly high	Be successful
5. Fly the coop	Escape from a place

III **We know that the word 'fly' (of birds/insects) means to move through air using wings. Tick the words which have the same or nearly the same meaning.**

swoop, flit, paddle, flutter, ascend, float, ride, skim, sink, dart, hover, glide, descend, soar, shoot, spring, stay, fall, sail, flap

✔ ANSWER

Words to tick: **swoop, flit, flutter, ascend, float, skim, dart, hover, glide, descend, soar, shoot, sail, flap**

Not ticked: paddle, ride, sink, spring, stay, fall (these do not mean moving through the air using wings).

⭐ The Black Aeroplane · Writing

1 **Have you ever been alone or away from home during a thunderstorm? Narrate your experience in a paragraph.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Caught in a Thunderstorm

Last July I was returning alone from my tuition class when the sky suddenly turned dark. Within minutes there was lightning and loud thunder, and heavy rain began to fall. The road was empty and the streetlights went off. I was frightened and remembered that one should not stand under a tree, so I ran to the verandah of a closed shop. Water filled the road and strong winds rattled the tin roofs. Every flash of lightning made my heart jump. After about half an hour, a kind shopkeeper nearby called me inside and let me phone my father. Soon my father arrived with an umbrella and a torch. I was soaked but safe. That evening I learnt to always carry an umbrella and to stay calm in danger.

🤔 How to Tell Wild Animals · Thinking about the Poem

1 **Does ‘dyin’ really rhyme with ‘lion’? Can you say it in such a way that it does?**

✔ ANSWER

No, ‘dyin’ does not really rhyme with ‘lion’. But if we pronounce ‘lion’ as ‘lyin’ (in one syllable, like ‘dyin’) or say ‘dyin’ as ‘dy-un’ like ‘li-on’, they can be made to rhyme. The poet takes this liberty to keep the rhyme and the humour.

2 **How does the poet suggest that you identify the lion and the tiger? When can you do so, according to him?**

✔ ANSWER

- **Asian Lion:** a large, tawny (yellowish-brown) beast that roars at you while you are dying.
- **Bengal Tiger:** a noble wild beast with black stripes on a yellow background, who eats you.

According to the poet, you can identify them only when they attack you — when you are dying or being eaten. This is the humour: by then it is too late.

3 **Do you think the words ‘lept‘ and ‘lep’ in the third stanza are spelt correctly? Why does the poet spell them like this?**

✔ ANSWER

No. The correct words are ‘leapt’ and ‘leap’.

The poet spells them as ‘lept’ and ‘lep’ to make them rhyme with ‘peppered’ and ‘Leopard’ (pronounced ‘lepperd’). This is poetic licence, used to keep the rhyme and rhythm and add humour.

4 **Do you know what a ‘bearhug’ is? It’s a friendly and strong hug — such as bears are thought to give, as they attack you! Again, hyenas are thought to laugh, and crocodiles to weep (‘crocodile tears’) as they swallow their victims. Are there similar expressions and popular ideas about wild animals in your own language(s)?**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

Yes. Some Hindi expressions:

- **घड़ियाली आँसू बहाना** – to shed crocodile tears (show false sorrow).
- **रंगा सियार** – a dyed jackal: a cheat who pretends to be what he is not.
- **भीगी बिल्ली बनना** – to become a wet cat: to be very meek out of fear.
- **गिरगिट की तरह रंग बदलना** – to change colours like a chameleon: to change one's views for selfish gain.
- **हाथी के दाँत खाने के और, दिखाने के और** – an elephant's teeth: saying one thing and doing another.

- Popular ideas: the fox is clever, the owl is foolish (उल्लू), the lion is the king of the jungle.

5 **Look at the line “A novice might nonplus”. How would you write this ‘correctly’? Why is the poet’s ‘incorrect’ line better in the poem?**

✔ ANSWER

Correct form: "A novice might be nonplussed" (A beginner might be puzzled).

The poet's line is better in the poem because it keeps the rhythm (number of beats) and rhymes with ‘thus’. The short, unusual phrase also adds to the humour.

6 **Can you find other examples of poets taking liberties with language, either in English or in your own language(s)? Can you find examples of humorous poems in your own language(s)?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Examples of poetic liberty:

- Robert Frost (‘Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening’): "Whose woods these are I think I know" — the word order is changed for rhyme.

- In this book, ‘The Ball Poem’ and ‘Amanda!’ use unusual sentence order; poets often write ‘o’er’ for ‘over’ and ‘’tis’ for ‘it is’ (as in this poem).
- In Hindi poetry, poets shorten or change words for rhyme, e.g. ‘नैन’ for ‘नयन’, ‘मोहि’ for ‘मुझे’.

Humorous poems in Hindi: the hasya kavitas of Kaka Hathrasi, Surendra Sharma and Ashok Chakradhar; children's rhymes like ‘मछली जल की रानी है’.

7 **Much of the humour in the poem arises from the way language is used, although the ideas are funny as well. If there are particular lines in the poem that you especially like, share these with the class, speaking briefly about what it is about the ideas or the language that you like or find funny.**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

Sample answer: I like the lines "Just notice if he eats you. / This simple rule may help you learn / The Bengal Tiger to discern." The idea is funny because the ‘simple rule’ works only after the tiger has eaten you, when you can no longer learn anything. The calm, polite tone makes a deadly situation sound like a lesson.

I also like "Hyenas come with merry smiles; / But if they weep they're Crocodiles." It plays on the popular ideas of the laughing hyena and crocodile tears.

Last stanza: "If there is nothing on the tree, / 'Tis the chameleon you see" — you 'see' the chameleon by seeing nothing, because it changes colour.

🤔 The Ball Poem · Thinking about the Poem

1 **Why does the poet say, "I would not intrude on him"? Why doesn't he offer him money to buy another ball?**

✔ ANSWER

The poet does not want to disturb the boy because the boy is learning an important lesson — how to accept loss. Intruding would stop him from facing his grief and growing up.

He does not offer money because the loss is not about the ball's price. The ball was linked to the boy's memories. A dime or another ball is "worthless" in replacing them; "Money is external".

2 **"... staring down/All his young days into the harbour where/His ball went ..." Do you think the boy has had the ball for a long time? Is it linked to the memories of days when he played with it?**

✔ ANSWER

Yes, the boy seems to have had the ball for a long time. The words "All his young days" suggest that he had played with it throughout his childhood.

So it is linked to happy memories of those days. As he stares into the harbour, he feels he has lost not just a ball but a part of his childhood.

3 **What does "in the world of possessions" mean?**

✔ ANSWER

It means the world in which people own things (money and material objects). In such a world things will be lost, taken away or destroyed — "balls will be lost always". Each person has the responsibility of looking after what he owns and learning to bear its loss.

4 **Do you think the boy has lost anything earlier? Pick out the words that suggest the answer.**

✔ ANSWER

No, it seems this is the first time he has lost something he loved. The words "He senses first responsibility" suggest that this is his first experience of loss. His "ultimate shaking grief" and the way he stands "rigid, trembling" also show he has not faced such a loss before.

5 **What does the poet say the boy is learning from the loss of the ball? Try to explain this in your own words.**

✔ ANSWER

The boy is learning "the epistemology of loss" — what it means to lose something. He learns that things we own will be lost or taken away, and money cannot buy back what we lose or the memories linked to it.

Most importantly, he learns "how to stand up": to accept the loss, bear the pain and move on. This is a lesson every person must learn one day, and most people learn it many times in life. Thus he takes his first step towards becoming mature and responsible.

6 **Have you ever lost something you liked very much? Write a paragraph describing how you**

felt then, and saying whether — and how — you got over your loss.

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Losing My Grandfather's Pen

When I was in Class 8, I lost a fountain pen my grandfather had given me on my birthday. I had used it for every exam since then. I dropped it somewhere on the way back from school. When I found my pencil box empty, I felt a sinking feeling. I searched the road twice and could not sleep that night. My mother offered to buy me a new pen, but I knew no pen could replace that one, because it carried my grandfather's love. Slowly I realised that the pen was only a thing; the memories and his blessings were still with me. My grandfather smiled and told me to keep working hard. I got over my loss by accepting it, and since then I take better care of the things I value.

🎉 **Chapter 3 done! Revise the answers once more tomorrow.**